The AI Dilemma: Qualitative Content Analysis Paper

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Intro & Methodology

Our dataset contained 5,854 viewer comments under The AI Dilemma video by the Center for Humane Technology. We randomly pulled 45 comments from across the dataset to ensure we had a representative sample. We began at multiple points in the comment section: the beginning, middle, and end, and selected comments in irregular intervals. We coded the 45 comments by identifying key sentiments and ideas within each, then cross-analyzed them to determine recurring themes. We then uploaded the entire comment section into ChatGPT and asked it to identify emergent themes we may have missed, the most frequent themes, co-occurring themes, and unusual outliers. ChatGPT explained that several of our pre-defined themes were clearly present in the raw comment data, and identified four other prominent themes we hadn't considered. We decided to integrate two of those four that would be worthwhile to explore. The purpose of using both manual AI coding is to help strengthen our analysis. We found that by using both approaches, we could:

- Cross-check patterns and themes. ChatGPT independently identified similar themes to ours, increasing confidence in our findings.

- Understand breadth and depth. When manually coding, we understand emotional tone and implied meaning– two things AI may miss. Using ChatGPT, we processed and gained insight into all the comments in the dataset.

Codes & Themes

We identified seven key themes from common sentiments and ideas expressed by commenters.

Disbelief and Cognitive Overwhelm

This theme refers to a common sentiment of awe and struggle to comprehend AI's rapid development, capabilities, and power. Examples of disbelief and cognitive overwhelm:

"It's hard to even partially process this for me. More astonishing is that there are not sirens going off everywhere"

"All of this can be overwhelming to contemplate."

Anxiety and Powerlessness

Anxiety and powerlessness refer to commenters' expressions of panic, urgency, and lack of control over society's future when considering the consequences of AI. Examples of anxiety and powerlessness:

"We have to face the fact that an extremely powerful tool is unstoppable is being developed of which we have no idea what impact it will have. "

"I'm afraid, there will be no stopping it."

Call to Action

Call to action refers to the common theme of commenters to express a desire or demand for concrete action, intervention, or awareness in response to the risks and harms of AI. Some examples of call to action:

"This NEEDS to be broadcasted everywhere, immediately, by any and all means necessary, so WE can make the choice to proceed or not."

"it's crucial to address these concerns and ensure the deployment of AI is accompanied by adequate safety measures."

"It is imperative we slow down our public deployment of GLLMM AIs."

AI Utopianism and Dystopianism

We identified two contrasting narratives about AI among commenters: optimism (AI will solve significant societal problems, increase efficiency, or even create a utopian future) and pessimism (AI will cause loss of control, chaos, or destruction). Combining these two narratives into one theme could better capture the mix of emotions and the tension people feel about AI's future. Examples of AI utopianism and dystopianism:

"Either a Star Trek-like utopia… or we end up in a dystopia."

"Thats so amazing. AI is so intelligent!"

Praise

Praise refers to the positive feedback commenters gave to the speakers in the video, specifically expressions of gratitude for sharing and informing. For example:

"I have been avidly researching AI safety, and this is the best primer I have found on the subject for a general audience. Thank you so much for this wonderful presentation."

"Incredible and much needed discussion. Thank you"

AI as existential risk

ChatGPT identified this theme. It includes comments where people fear AI could threaten human survival or rewrite society. It covers commenters who expressed feelings that AI could lead to catastrophic, irreversible harm to humanity. Some examples of AI as existential risk:
"We're already in the first steps of hell, this just turns it into a slide."
"There's already a good chance social media will cause us to go extinct. Shut this down."
"It seems to me that a problem leading to catastrophe is highly likely. Remember, a lot of suffering exists between here and human extinction."

Human nature/misuse

This theme was the second identified by ChatGPT that we integrated. It refers to comments suggesting the real danger isn't AI itself, but AI in the wrong hands. The comments blame greed, ignorance, or lack of morality for the future unintended consequences of AI. For example:
"I work in IT and, unfortunately, I think the monster is not AI, in and of itself. Many people often don't think critically nor, as we have seen in the past few years, logically"
"In the end, I believe that the biggest issue is that AI is easily exploited and measures need to be taken to responsibly deploy any AI tech."

Pattern Analysis

Manual code trend scan

Several critical patterns appeared after analysis of our manual codes. Many individuals have intertwining feelings regarding topics raised by "The A.I. Dilemma," commonly worry, but also have an interest. The most common sentiments were praise, concern, fear, disbelief, and pessimism about society's future with artificial intelligence. A mix of praise and wonder about technology's role in users' everyday lives was represented, with a commenter writing, "The best collection of current applications and future risks of AI... AI safety needs to be part of the general conversation ASAP." This praise often shifted to fear with comments describing feeling "upset" or "afraid" from an online safety perspective. These reactions suggest that individuals, while fascinated with AI, hold an underlying emotion deeply ingrained with anxiousness about its power and rapid growth. A significant theme that rose across the data was responsibility and

awareness. Several comments advocated for strong regulatory forces, for example: "we need this broadcast on every major new network" or "there should be alarms going off everywhere". We recognized a growing sense of fear and advocacy for better ethical use and transparency in AI systems. Many commenters had opposing views; some described AI as a tool that can be "cooperative," while others viewed it contrarily, stating it is "out of control". This tension highlights the broader social divide between individuals who see AI as a developed tool for the future that encourages significant progress and others who fear it, what it can become, and say it is a danger to human life. Finally, a few outlier commenters used humor and sarcasm to discuss their thoughts. One stated: "I'm EXCLUSIVELY interested in AI safety... since no global EMPs are scheduled for our planet, " expressing both irony and humor about AI's ongoing growth. Overall, the comments reflected a mix of fear, hope, and humor, all expressing a shared desire for accountability, transparency, and understanding in how AI continues to evolve within society.

AI-assisted trend scan.

Analyzing the YouTube comments on "The AI Dilemma" through ChatGPT AI assistance showed that most viewers felt a stronger negative emotion regarding AI, including fear, sadness, and frustration. Many commenters felt the video exposed that AI was developing too fast and becoming too powerful, prompting them to question AI's ethical and moral implications. Individuals often describe AI using terms like "doomed". These comments suggest that viewers saw AI more maliciously, where this technology crossed the line of being a tool and became more of an issue for morality and human society. A critical tension appears between the commenters' battles between awareness and idealized hope. Many thank the presenters for touching up on the topic of AI, saying they would help distribute this video to reach a large number of people, whereas others emphasized that it was "far too late" to make a difference. While users want to act and implement a universal understanding of AI, they feel powerless to make a difference. Finally, some comments brought in outside views that were religious. Users would connect AI to events within the Bible, expressing an end of humanity or simply commenting, "Jesus loves you". ChatGPT also identified outlier perspectives as philosophical outlooks reflecting what technology is doing or how it impacts humans and their identities: "If this translation of brain activity is correct... it shows how central identity and empathy are to the

mind". Some commenters use a philosophical way of focusing on how the human sense of self and ability to connect are critical parts of the mind and are essentially being deterred by AI. Overall, the comments between the manually coded and AI-assisted trends show a mix of moral, technical, and human concern laced with confusion and a desire for liberation. While both scans showed gratefulness, each was intertwined with anger at the lack of awareness before the video. These dominant patterns show the comments' struggle with uncertainty and anxiety about what AI will become and their control over it, if any.

Critical Reflection Product

The comments of this video reveal key insights about public attitudes towards AI. Most of our identified themes connect to the fear of AI. This feeling of fear is most likely amplified by the narrative in the AI Dilemma discussion, as the authors center the talk around risks and potential harms of AI. The sentiment holds, however, that people are scared of AI and its consequences, expressing the issues of child safety, unequal access to technology, the persuasive power of AI, and, most significantly, job loss. Many comments reflected viewers' desire for ethical and policy considerations in AI development. Some users advocated for instating safeguards and more public awareness, while others worried corporations might misuse regulation or fail to implement it effectively. The comments inform us that individuals view AI as a function and a harm to society.

Manual coding allowed us to understand how people relate to other commenters and their relationships with AI. The AI-assisted analysis helped reveal broader patterns, like urgency or philosophical reflection. Occasionally, AI misinterprets tone or context, like taking sarcastic terms as genuine. When manual coding, we can understand those cues. By combining both methods, we concluded that, while individuals recognized AI benefits, they fear associated risks and call for cautious engagement with AI.

Critical Reflection Process

The main weakness of this process is how time-consuming it is to work with so much data while trying to hand-code every piece of information thoroughly. AI tools can make this an effective method that gives insight into all the data without investing nearly as much time as you would have initially. A weakness of this process is the lack of depth, because the comments of a

YouTube video can only go so deep. It's mostly surface-level, quick thoughts. However, a strength of using comments is that they are entirely voluntary, so you learn how the audience responds to a video rather than how they would react to a question. It's like being able to give a survey where, instead of a written question, you can present a video or image, and people will spit out the primary thoughts that come to mind, which is also a form of helpful feedback/data. A large strength is that the comments likely come from users interested in the video's content because of how algorithms and feeds work. So, unlike a randomly dispersed survey, your sample might consist of people more drawn to that topic or content. This is unique and significant to this form of data collection.

References

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